

7.2 IM Tools

The messenger, as discussed in chapter 4, is a client that allows instant text communication between two or more people over a network. Instant messaging differs from e-mail in that conversations happen in real-time. IM services also have a ‘presence awareness’ feature, indicating whether people on one’s list of contacts are currently online. Instant messaging applications may also include the ability to post an ‘away’ message, the equivalent of the message on a telephone answering machine.

Popular instant messaging services on the Internet include MSN Messenger, Yahoo! Messenger, and ICQ. These services owe many ideas and the seed technology to the older online chat medium known as Internet Relay Chat (IRC). An early form of instant messaging was implemented on the PLATO system in the early 1970s. ICQ was the first general instant messenger introduced to the Internet, in November 1996. After its introduction, a number of variations of instant messaging have arisen in parallel, and each application has its own protocols. The phrase ‘instant message’ was coined by Paul M A Linebarger in the science-fiction stories he wrote in the 1960s.

Instant messaging has been fragmented because of a number of dif



MSN Messenger



Trillian Multi client messenger